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THA 215: Basic Film Analysis and Appreciation - Reading the Moving Image

From shot to sequence: how films mean what they mean

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Film analysis is close reading with a stopwatch. This pack teaches you to break a sequence into shots, analyse framing, movement, editing, sound and performance, and write an analysis that cites timecodes as evidence. It includes Nollywood and African cinema examples rather than a Hollywood-only canon.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Break a sequence into shots and describe each accurately.
- Analyse framing, camera movement, lighting and colour.
- Explain continuity, montage and editing rhythm.
- Write a timecode-based analysis of a short sequence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Mise-en-scene and cinematography

Everything in the frame is a decision.

- Mise-en-scene: setting, props, costume, performance and lighting within the frame.
- Framing: shot size, angle, headroom, composition and depth.
- Movement: pan, tilt, dolly, handheld and crane each carry a different feel.
- Lens and focus: wide lenses exaggerate space; long lenses compress it.
- Lighting: direction, contrast and colour temperature shape mood and meaning.
- Production design communicates period, class and character before dialogue begins.

Editing and sound

The cut is the basic unit of film grammar.

- Continuity editing preserves spatial and temporal logic for the viewer.
- Montage creates meaning through juxtaposition rather than continuity.
- Cutting rhythm controls pace and emotional pressure.
- Sound design: dialogue, ambience, effects and music; diegetic versus non-diegetic.
- Silence is a designed choice, not an absence.
- Sound bridges link scenes and smooth transitions.

> **Cite timecodes**
> '01:12:30 to 01:14:05' is evidence. 'The scene where she cries' is not. Timestamps make your argument checkable.

Writing the analysis

Structure beats adjectives.

1. State your claim about how the sequence produces meaning.
2. Describe the sequence's duration and position in the film.
3. Analyse two or three formal elements in detail.
4. Quote dialogue exactly and give timecodes.
5. Connect form to theme, genre or context.
6. Avoid plot summary except where it is necessary to your argument.

The sequence is the unit of meaning

A single shot can be beautiful and mean very little. Meaning appears when shots are placed next to each other, because the cut creates a relationship the audience completes. Two neutral images in sequence produce a third idea: a face, then a plate of food, reads as hunger or refusal depending on the performance in the first shot.

This is why film analysis should begin with the sequence rather than the frame. Identify where a sequence starts and ends (usually by a change of place, time or argument), then ask what question the sequence poses and how the editing answers it. A chase sequence poses "will they escape?" and answers it with rhythm: shots shorten as pressure rises.

Mise-en-scene - everything within the frame - is the other half. Setting, costume, lighting, colour, the arrangement of bodies and the choice of what is left out all communicate before a character speaks. Learn to describe a frame neutrally first ("she sits at the far end of a long table, lit from one side, the other chair empty"), then interpret. Description first protects you from inventing.